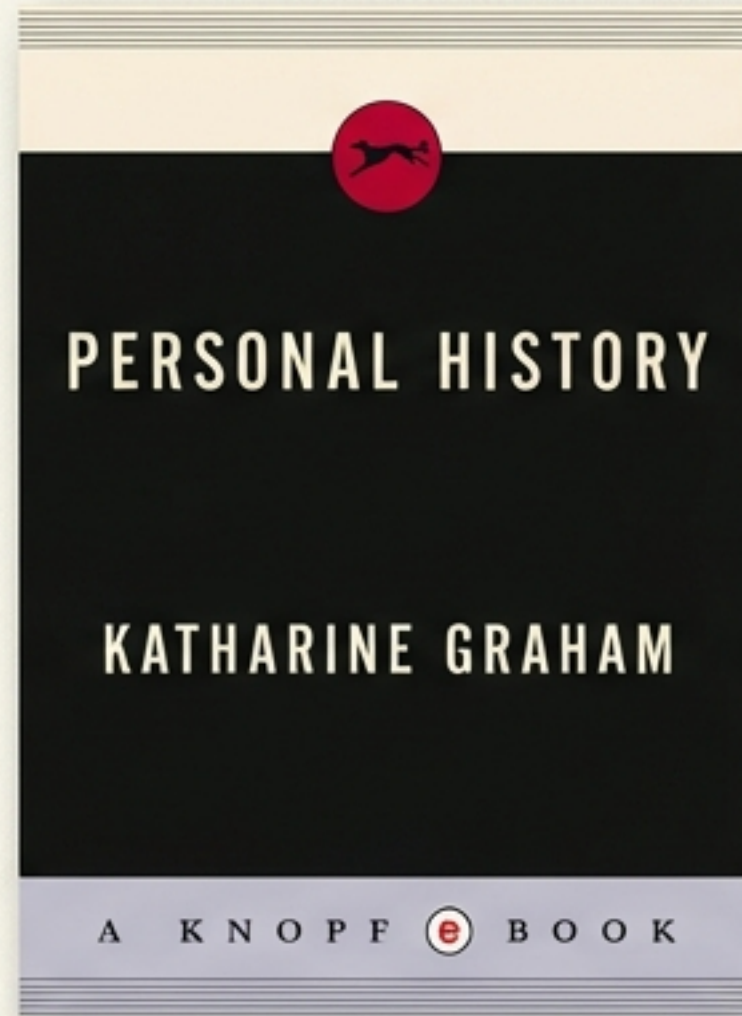


The Making of Katharine Graham

A Case Study in Wealth, Power, and the Forging of a Publisher



From a disciplined, wealthy upbringing to the chaotic waterfronts of San Francisco, this document traces the origins of one of the 20th century's most powerful women.

Based on her autobiography, *Personal History*.

The Merger: Wall Street Meets Bohemia

The unexpected encounter
that shaped a dynasty.

Eugene Meyer (32)	Agnes Ernst (21)
• Wealthy financier • Driving a Stanley Steamer • Pragmatic & Serious	• Freelance journalist (NY Sun) • Strikingly beautiful • Bohemian & Artistic



February
12, 1908 –
23rd St.
Gallery

Eugene spots Agnes at a Japanese print exhibit. He tells his friend Edgar Kohler, “That’s the girl I’m going to marry.”

Kohler bets against him.

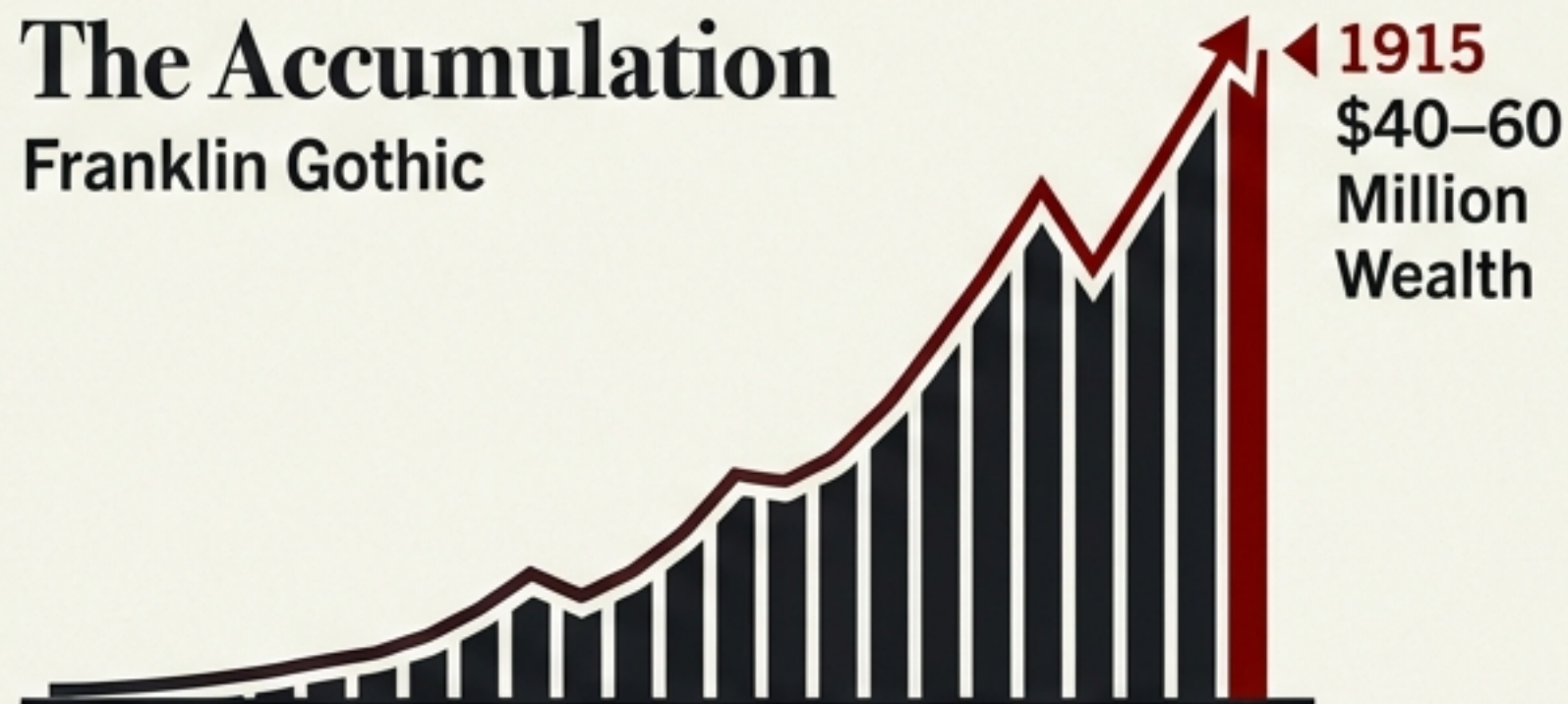
They married exactly two years later, on Lincoln’s Birthday, 1910.

“ From this particular string of accidental happenings all the rest followed. ”

Eugene Meyer: The Pragmatist

Jewish heritage,
French roots.
Son of a Lazard
Frères partner.
Struck out on his
own in 1901.

The Accumulation
Franklin Gothic



The Map of Life Plan Bodoni

Age 20–40: Competence & Family

Age 40–60: Public Service

Served under seven presidents, including as Chairman of the War Finance Corporation and Governor of the Federal Reserve.

“Watch
that fellow
Meyer.
He’ll have
all the
money.”

Agnes Ernst: The Intellectual

The Persona

in Franklin Gothic

- Lutheran heritage.
- “The Sun Girl.”
- Bohemian, ambitious, self-absorbed. Friend of Steichen and Rodin.

The Ambition

in Franklin Gothic

- To live life on a “high plane.”
- Fell in love with Chinese art; published a book on the subject.

The Contract

in Franklin Gothic

- Married Eugene partly to escape her father’s debts.
- Money meets Art.

“*It would have been impossible for me to marry anyone who was not well-to-do... Let no one undervalue the importance of economic independence.*”

The Crucible: Growing Up in the 'Meyer Myth'

The Farm (Mount Kisco) - Granite house, indoor pools
Crescent Place (DC) - 40 rooms, Impressionist art

Rules of the House

1. **Perfectionism:** Bilingual, athletic, intellectually superior.
2. **Isolation:** Raised by nurses and governesses (specifically "Powelly").
3. **Emotional Distance:** Mother was conscientious but scarcely loving.

Katharine's Role: The "Goody Two-Shoes." Safe but overlooked. A "tattle-tale" wanting to belong.

The Bargain: ‘Sold Out for a Nickel’



Father: “Well, now will you be my secretary?”

Katharine: “Yes.”

From age eight, Eugene groomed Katharine for a supporting role. When she needed one nickel to reach the \$5.00 mark in her bank, she accepted the premise that her future lay in service to him. **It was a joke** that carried the weight of destiny.

The Silent Curriculum: Three Taboos



Money

Small allowances, hand-me-downs. “You couldn’t just be a rich kid; you had to do something.”



Jewishness

Never discussed. Katharine played Shylock in school without knowing she was Jewish. “I was totally—incredibly—unaware of anti-Semitism.”



Sex

Totally ignored. Agnes’s advice on reproduction: “Haven’t you seen dogs in the street?”

Impact: A naive “Goody Two-Shoes” forced to learn reality through collision.

The Turnaround: Buying *The Post* (1933)



1. Context: The Post is bankrupt. Ruined by Ned McLean.

2. The Event: A public auction on the building steps.

3. The Drama: Cissy Patterson stalls to bid higher. Eugene Meyer bids anonymously via agent George E. Hamilton, Jr.

4. The Family Reaction: Katharine (at Madeira School) learns casually from her mother: "Oh darling, didn't anyone tell you? Dad has bought the Post."

Impact: A pivotal moment where destiny was casually revealed, shaping Katharine's future leadership.

Mentally, Morally, and Physically Bankrupt

Status Report 1933

CIRCULATION

- Circulation: 50,000

DEBTS

- Debts: \$600,000+

REPUTATION

- Reputation: Ruined by Teapot Dome scandal

Eugene's 7 Principles

- 1. The first mission is to tell the truth.**
- 2. The newspaper shall not be the ally of any special interest.**
- 3. Be prepared to sacrifice material fortunes for the public good.**

The Reality: Eugene lost **\$1.3 million** in 1935 alone. He poured his fortune into the paper, viewing it as a **public trust**.

The **Comics War**: Meyer vs. Cissy Patterson

The **Antagonist**

Cissy Patterson, editor of the rival Herald. Cousin of Colonel McCormick. Stole “Dick Tracy” and “Andy Gump” from the Post.

The **Conflict**

The **“Raw Meat” Incident**. After losing in court, Cissy sent Eugene a box with a piece of raw meat and a note: “So as not to disappoint you” (Shylock reference).

Eugene Meyer’s response: “Cissy, if you don’t stop lying about me, I’m going to start telling the **truth about you**.”

The Awakening: Vassar & The Left



The Transition: Arrives at Vassar as a naive conservative.

Katharine enters Vassar College with conservative beliefs inherited from her upbringing, initially unaware of broader political ideologies.

The Shift: Influence of the New Deal. Joins the American Student Union (liberals and communists).

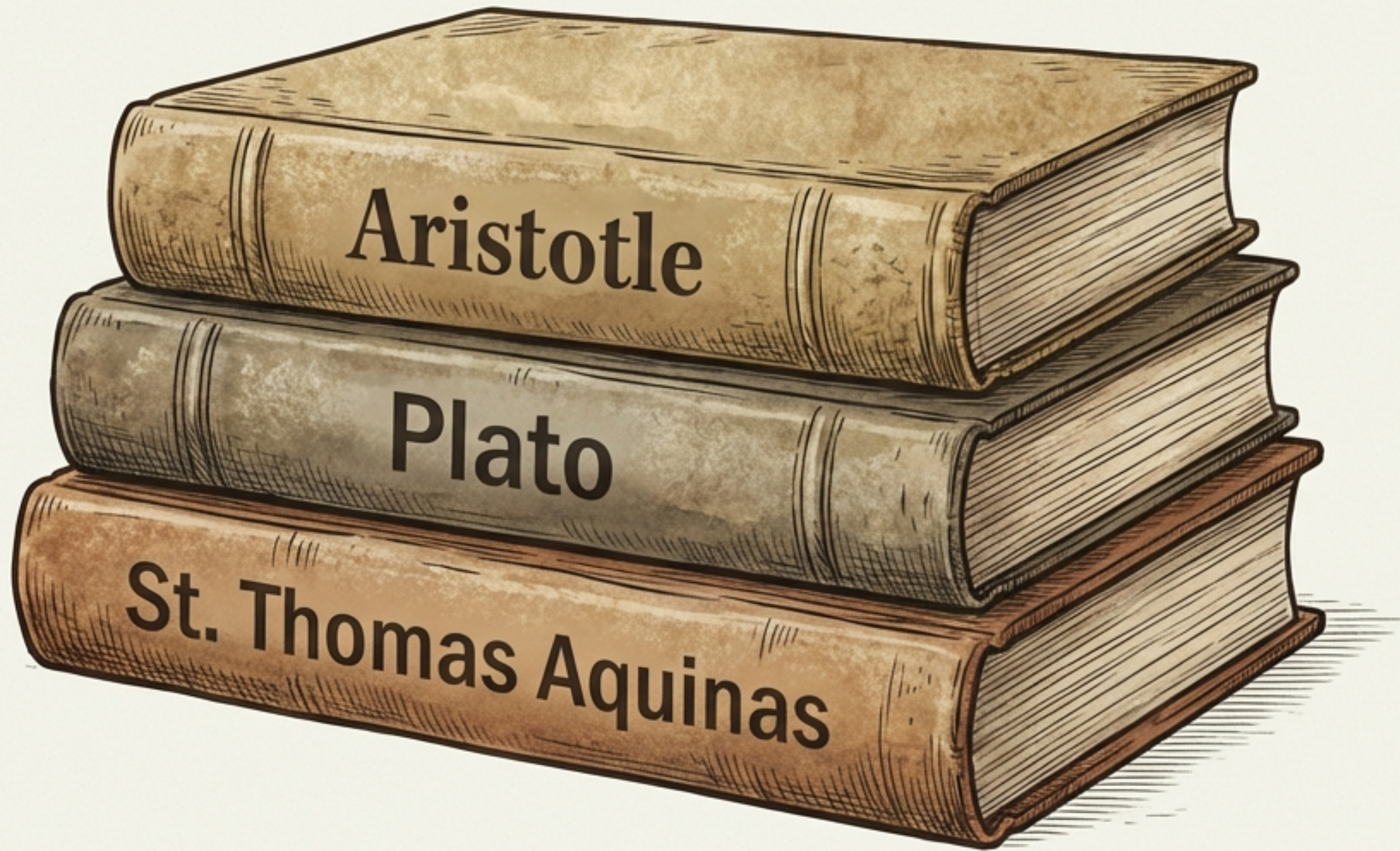
Influenced by New Deal politics and the political atmosphere on campus, she aligns herself with the left-leaning American Student Union, exposing her to a spectrum of liberal and communist viewpoints.

The Friction: Agnes is anti-Roosevelt ("Landon is a home run"). Eugene advises against labels but respects her judgment.

Her mother, Agnes, remains staunchly anti-Roosevelt, declaring "Landon is a home run," while Eugene discourages rigid political labels yet supports Katharine's developing perspective.

Katharine begins to form an identity separate from the "Meyer Myth." "My little conservative voice will scarcely be heard... but it will be fun baiting the bears."

The Crucible of Intellect: University of Chicago



The Environment

A ferment of ideas under President Hutchins. No football, focus on “Great Books.”

The Course

Two hours of Socratic bullying by Hutchins and Adler. “Miss Meyer, tell us in your own words what Aristotle thinks.”

Social Life

Living in International House. Discussions of Thomas Mann. First encounters with anti-Semitism at the Quadrangle Club.

Confronting Reality: The Republic Steel Strike



South Chicago, 1937

Katharine accompanies a stringer to a strike.

The Violence

Police fired on strikers.
Seven killed. Katharine fled
the scene in chaos.

The Aftermath

She returned to the plant,
using the Washington Post
name to get a management
tour.

“Casey Jones (Post Editor): ‘The picture we’d received of the way a big strike works was equivalent to a year’s work in any economics course.’”

The Apprentice: San Francisco

The San Francisco News

Date September 1937

Employee Name Katharine Meyer \$ \$21.00

_____ Dollars

Pone **PAID** _____

J. Editor
Editor

The Job

Scrappy afternoon tabloid. Tracking down photos, writing snippets.

The Crisis

Overwhelmed by fear of failure, she tried to quit.

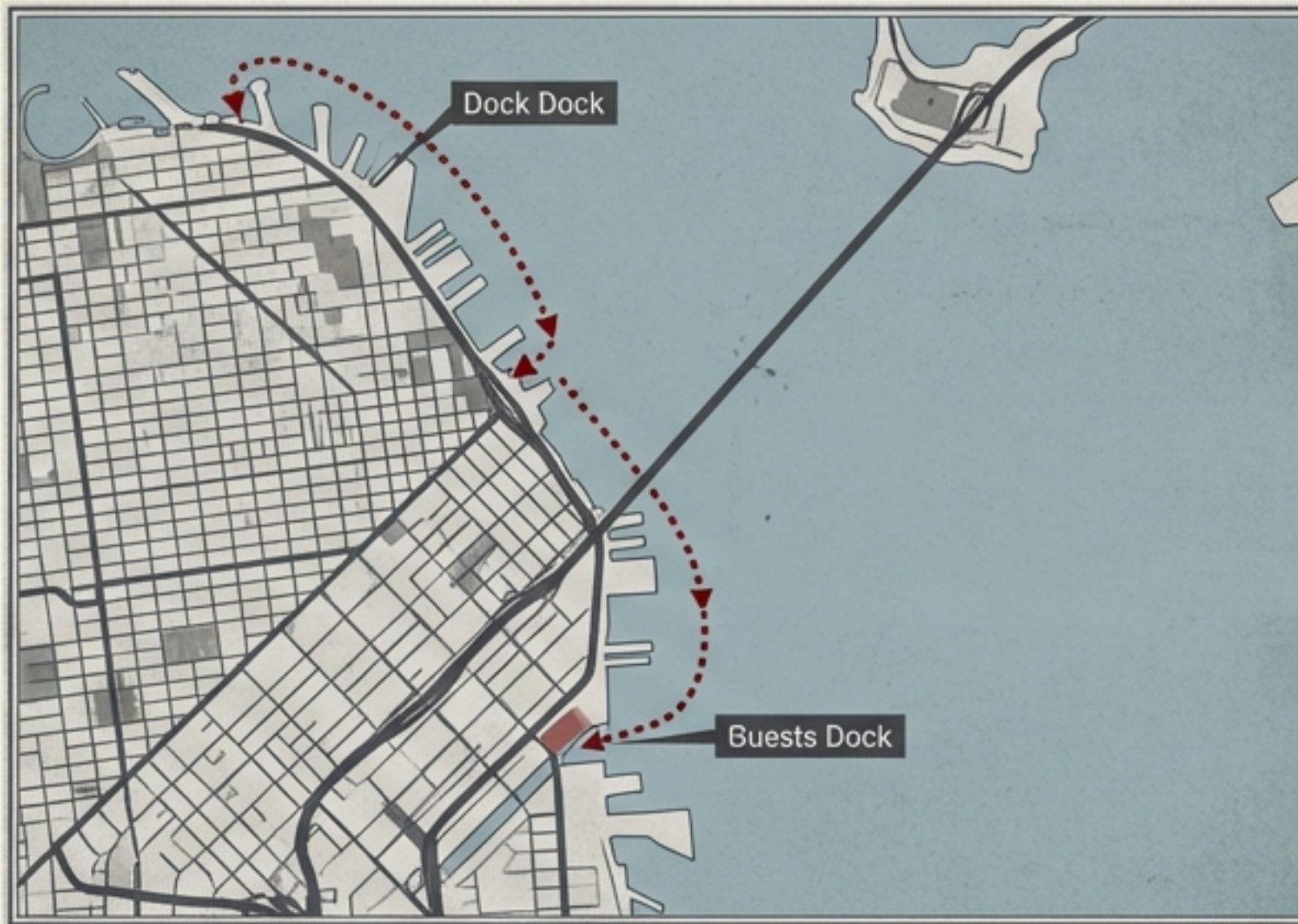
Eugene's Advice

“If you aren’t worth the whole \$21 a week now, you’d be worth much more than that later.”

The Assignment

Luring the Women’s Christian Temperance Union into bars for a story.

The Waterfront Beat: The 'Hot Car'



Map: Tracing the 'Hot Car' along the San Francisco waterfront.

Assignment

Legman for labor reporter Bob Elliott.

The Cast

Harry Bridges (Radical head of ILWU) and Eugene "Pat" Patton (Charismatic warehouse leader).

The Conflict

Tracking the 'Hot Car' (freight loaded by strikebreakers) to trigger lockouts.

The Lifestyle

Drinking 'boilermakers' (whiskey and beer) for 25 cents in waterfront bars.

The Spy in the Union Hall

Editor's Red

The Secret.

Katharine hid her identity. Henry Melnikow warned: “Be careful, we have a spy in our midst.”



Franklin Gothic

Franklin Gothic

Editor's Red

The Reveal.

At the Opera, wearing black velvet and leopard skin, she is spotted by union negotiator Sam Kagel.

“Well, Harry, black velvet and leopard skin, what do you think of that?”

The Manifesto: “The Meyer Octopus”

I am good with a nit, the performance, buyer tentacles clutch deep. deep. I would your story, book to mine over the Meyer tentacles

→ **Meyer tentacles clutch deep.**

from the post on to be very shot. I inreuch my Post, and bent

I detest beyond description
advertising and circulation.

tain fruerds. I think I onto go to persour writing that have

→ **I think I want to go into the
newspaper business... I like to write.**

the reader's at... but the rabbit I am sit

Written to her sister Bis in 1937. She acknowledges the pull of the Post but fears being “an automaton.” She predicts she will marry “A MAN” because she doesn’t like to live alone.

The Unspoken Bond



Despite the ‘Secretary’ jokes, Eugene believed in Katharine more than she believed in herself.

Evidence:

- He hoarded her letters.
- He wrote to her about the Post’s battles as if she were a partner.

“I’m not sure why I wasn’t aware of it at the time, but it’s clear to me now that he believed in me, which became a very powerful emotional asset.”

From 'Goody Two-Shoes' to Publisher

The “Origin Story” is complete. The foundation for the woman who would later publish the Pentagon Papers was built not just in the boardrooms, but in the friction between her parents’ worlds and the grit of the reporter’s life.

1917

Born into the
“Meyer Myth”.

1933

Post purchased
for \$825,000.

1934-38

Awakening at
Vassar/Chicago.

1939

*The Waterfront
Apprentice.*

